

NOBODY SHOULD KNOW WHICH ONE THEY GOT

You already differentiate. The question this page is about is narrower and almost never asked: **does the student need to know which version they were given?** Usually they can tell — the colored paper, the group name, the sheet marked B. This is about taking that away, and why that is easier than it sounds.

The argument, and it is not the one you are expecting.

The label does no teaching work. A student cannot act on "you are on tier two." It is not feedback, it is a status. **A thing that does no work and may cost something should go** — and the useful discovery is that it costs you almost nothing to remove.

4

things that have to match, or
the tier shows

6

ways to do it on paper, with no
software

1

research claim I expected to
make and cannot

Where this comes from

The reading in the software I run for my own high school woodshop course comes in three levels. Same question bank at every level, same key terms, and the level moves on its own as a student improves. **Nothing on the student's screen names a level, shows a badge, or hints that anybody got different text.** That rule is one line in the spec and it is the whole of this page.

The idea underneath, which shows up everywhere

Build it so the wrong thing is impossible, rather than so that you are careful. A form with no box for a last name cannot leak one. A screen with nowhere to print a level cannot label a child. Being careful fails on the day you are tired; **a thing that cannot happen does not need you to be careful.**

What the research actually says

I expected to open this page with "research shows labeling harms students." **I went and read it, and it does not say that.** Here is what it does say, because you should have the real version before you change anything in your room.

The best-known meta-analysis found the opposite of a crisis

Kulik and Kulik, 1984, pooling **31 studies** of ability grouping in elementary schools, reported "**significant positive effects on the academic performance of elementary school children**" — a small benefit, moving a typical student from the 50th to the 58th percentile.

And on the part this page is about, the same analysis found grouping had "**trivially small effects on the self-concepts of elementary school pupils.**" Not devastating. Trivially small.

The concerns are real but contested, and later work is mixed

There is a long literature on placement bias and on students in low groups internalizing what the group says about them, and there is also work finding no such contrast effect. **Anybody who tells you this question is settled has not read enough of it.**

So why hide the tier at all?

Because the argument was never the research. **It is that the label does nothing.** Ask what a student is supposed to do differently on learning they are on tier two. There is no answer. It carries no instruction, no next step and no way to improve — **it is a fact about them rather than about their work.**

And that makes it a cheap decision rather than a brave one

You are not weighing a benefit against a risk. **You are removing something with no upside and an argued-about downside,** and page 3 says what it costs to remove: four things have to match. That is the whole price.

Match these, or the tier shows anyway

Children are extremely good at this. **Hiding the label is not enough if everything else gives it away,** and these are the four that give it away.

1 • The same questions

Not easier questions for the easier passage. **The same question bank at every level.** If the questions differ, the versions are visibly different work and the whole thing collapses the moment two students compare. It also keeps the assessment honest: you are changing how hard the *reading* is, not what you are asking them to know.

2 • The same key terms

Every version uses the real vocabulary. **Simplifying the sentences is differentiation; removing the words of the subject is a different and smaller course.** A student on the simplest version still says "photosynthesis," still writes it, still owns it.

3 • The same look and roughly the same length

Same font, same layout, same number of paragraphs, same paper. **No colored paper, no letters in the corner, no "Version B."** Two sheets the same shape on the same desk tell a room nothing.

4 • The same expectations out loud

Same deadline, same instructions, same tone when you hand it over. **This is the one that leaks,** and it leaks through kindness — "take your time with this one" said gently to one table announces the whole system.

And one rule about movement.

When a student moves up a level, **say nothing and change nothing visible.** The reward for getting better is not an announcement; it is that the work fits again. If moving up is an event, then being moved down is an event too, and you have rebuilt the label with extra steps.

Six ways to do this on paper tomorrow

- 1 Print both versions identically**
Same paper, same font, same header. **If you need to tell them apart, put a tiny mark where you will look and a student will not** — a dot in the footer, a different staple corner. Not a letter in the top right.
- 2 Hand them out face down, in seating order**
Sorted beforehand. The thirty seconds of sorting at your desk replaces the entire visible system, and no student watches you decide anything.
- 3 Give the same instructions to the whole room**
One set, said once, to everybody. **Any instruction that only makes sense for one version is a leak.**
- 4 Keep the questions identical and put them on a separate sheet**
One question sheet for the room, handed out to everybody. Now the only thing that differs is the reading, which is the only thing you wanted to differ.
- 5 Never name a group after what it is**
If you must group, name them after nothing — colors, rivers, anything arbitrary — and **change the membership often enough that the names stop meaning anything.** A group name that stays stable all year is a label whatever you call it.
- 6 Move students quietly and often**
Small, frequent, unannounced adjustments. **Movement that is normal is not news,** and a system where nobody can be sure who is on what is a system where it stops mattering.

The test for whether it worked.

Ask a student which version they got. If they can tell you, something on this page is not being done. If they look at you blankly, you have it.

YOUR TURN

Find your leaks

Take one thing you already differentiate. **Walk it through as a student would see it**, and write down every point where they could work out which version they got.

What I differentiate, and how many versions

The four checks

Does it match across versions?	Yes / no	If no, what I will change
The questions		
The key terms		
The look and the length		
What I say out loud		

The one leak I had not noticed

If you want a tool that does this for you

Our **Vibe Coding for Teachers** build-alongs hand you a working classroom tool you own outright, with your own content going in from a setup screen and no code to edit. The rule on this page is the kind of thing you can build in once and never have to remember again. Search our store.

If this was useful, would you leave a review?

TPT gives you credit toward future purchases for every review, and it is the only thing that decides whether another teacher ever sees this. Source for page 2: Kulik and Kulik, *Effects of Ability Grouping on Elementary School Pupils: A Meta-Analysis*, 1984 (ERIC ED255329).